

Translation Handbook

دليل الترجمة



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A beginner's guide to translating between English and Arabic

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مرشد للمبتدئين في الترجمة بين العربية والإنجليزية

First edition, 2026

Translation Handbook: A Beginner's Guide to Translating between English and Arabic

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Preface

The Translation Team of the Guild Professional Club prepared this handbook for students taking their first steps in translation between English and Arabic. Use it in workshops or on your own.

By the end of it, you should:

- know the basic rules and principles of translation;
- understand the main **differences** between English and Arabic;
- recognise the main **difficulties** that translators meet;
- be able to use practical **strategies and techniques** to solve them;
- be able to check your own work and explain your choices.

The Translation Team

Acknowledgements

The Translation Team thanks every team member who collected material and examples for this handbook.

Start here

This book is for you if you have never studied translation. You do not need any background: only good English, good Arabic and curiosity. We will start from zero and go one step at a time.

What does a translator actually do?

Imagine you are walking in a park with a friend who reads only Arabic. You see a sign that says *Keep off the grass*. Your friend asks what it means.

You would not say ابقَ بعيداً عن العشب. You would say what an Arabic sign says in the same place: ممنوع الدوس على العشب. You understood the English, then said the same thing the way Arabic says it.

That is translation. Everything in this book grows from this simple idea.

The four steps of every translation

Whether you translate a sign, a letter or a book, you always do the same four things:

1. **Plan.** Ask who will read your translation and why.
2. **Understand.** Read the text until you know exactly what it means.
3. **Write.** Say the same thing in the other language, in a natural way.
4. **Check.** Read your translation again and correct it.

The chapters of this book teach you how to do each step better.

Your journey through this book

1. **First steps** (Part 1): what translation is, how to prepare, and how English and Arabic differ.
2. **Understanding meaning** (Parts 2 and 3): how words carry meaning, and how they work together.

3. **Solving problems** (Parts 4 and 5): the methods translators use when a word or an idea does not travel easily.
4. **Whole texts** (Part 6): how to read and translate a complete text, such as a news report.
5. **Tools and checking** (Parts 7 and 8): dictionaries, technology, and how to check and explain your work.
6. **Films and videos** (Part 9): subtitles and dubbing, the most advanced topic.

Read the parts in order: each one uses what you learned before it.

How each chapter guides you

- **Where we are** tells you what you already know and what comes next.
- The chapter explains each idea with examples in English and Arabic.
- **Try it** gives you a few questions, with the answers straight after.
- **Remember** sums up the chapter, and **Words to remember** gives the new terms with their Arabic equivalents. All the terms are also in the glossary at the end.

Signs used in this book

- **EN → AR**: from English into Arabic. **AR → EN**: from Arabic into English.
- ✓ marks a good translation and ✗ a poor one.
- The short notes in brackets, such as (Newmark, 1988), show where an idea comes from. The full sources are in the References.

Part 1: Getting started

Chapter 1: Translation and the translator

Where we are. This is your starting point. In this chapter you will see what translation really is, the different kinds of translation, and what you need to become a translator.

Step 1: translation carries meaning, not words

Remember the sign in the park (Start here): you did not read out the words one by one; you said what the sign **means**, in good Arabic. That is translation.

Here is what happens when we translate words instead of meaning. English speakers say *Break a leg!* to wish someone good luck, especially before a performance:

Word by word: **اكسر ساقاً** ❌ By meaning: **إبالتوفيق** ✓

Translation is often defined in the same way: “an activity or process of transferring textual meaning from one language to another” (Translation Team, n.d.), or “rendering the meaning of a text into another language in the way that the author intended the text” (Newmark, 1988, p. 5).

From now on, we call the original text the **source text** and your translation the **target text**.

Step 2: a translation is never a perfect copy

No two languages match perfectly, so you can never make an exact copy. You bring the meaning as close as you can. This is called **approximation**. Translation has been described as “saying almost the same thing”, the title of a book on translation (Eco, 2003).

And your translation must pass a basic test: your reader must understand it. If they do not, the translation has not worked.

Step 3: the different kinds of translation

People translate in several ways:

- **Written translation:** translating written texts. This is what this book teaches.
- **Interpreting:** translating speech, while the speaker is talking (simultaneous) or after the speaker stops (consecutive).
- **Sight translation:** reading a text written in one language and saying it aloud in another.
- **Audiovisual translation:** translating films, television and video games, for example with subtitles (Part 9).
- **Localisation:** adapting a product, such as a website or an app, to another country's language and culture.

In a wider sense, even rewording a text in the same language, or turning a story into a film, is a kind of translation (Jakobson, 1959). In this book, we focus on translating from one language into another.

Step 4: what you need to become a translator

Knowing two languages is the start, not the end. A good translator:

- knows both languages well;
- knows both **cultures** well (مُلمّ بالثقافتين);
- is curious and learns about the topic of each text;
- knows many expressions and idioms in both languages;
- keeps practising and checking their work.

This is not a new idea. More than a thousand years ago, an Arabic writer said that a translator must know both languages equally well (al-Jāhiz, 1965):

ولا بدّ للترجمان من أن يكونَ بياؤه في نفس الترجمة في وزنِ علمه في نفس المعرفة،
وينبغي أن يكونَ أعلمَ الناسَ باللغة المنقولة والمنقولِ إليها، حتى يكونَ فيهما سواءٌ
وغايةً.

Remember that a translator is a reader before being a writer: first understand the text fully, then write it again in the other language.

Step 5: who chooses the text?

Sometimes someone asks you to translate a text: a client, an agency or an employer. You are then a **commissioned translator**, and you follow their instructions (Chapter 2). Sometimes you choose the text yourself, such as a poem you love. You are then a **self-initiated translator**, and you make your own choices.

Freelance translators (who work for many clients) and in-house translators (who work for one employer) both do commissioned work, and any translator can also translate a text on their own initiative.

Try it

1. What is the difference between translation and interpreting?
2. A publisher asks you to translate a novel. Are you a commissioned or a self-initiated translator?
3. Why is translation called “approximation”?

Answers

1. Translation deals with written texts; interpreting deals with speech.
2. Commissioned: the publisher chose the text and asked you to translate it.
3. Because no two languages match perfectly, so the translator can only come as close as possible to the original meaning.

REMEMBER

- Translation carries **meaning**, not words, from one language to another.
- A good translator needs two languages **and** two cultures.
- Commissioned translators follow the client's instructions; self-initiated translators choose their own texts.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation** (الترجمة): Transferring meaning from one language into another. In a narrow sense, written translation (الترجمة التحريرية), as opposed to interpreting.
- **Interpreting** (الترجمة الشفهية): Transferring spoken language into another language.
- **Source text (ST)** (النص المصدر): The original text that you translate.
- **Target text (TT)** (النص الهدف): Your translation.
- **Approximation** (التقريب): Rendering the meaning of the source text as closely as possible in the target language, knowing that an exact match is impossible.
- **Commissioned translator** (مترجم بتكليف): A translator who translates a text at someone else's request.
- **Self-initiated translator** (مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية): A translator who chooses a text to translate on their own initiative.

Chapter 2: Tips, advice and preparation

Where we are. You now know what translation is. Before you translate your first sentence, you need to prepare. This chapter walks you through what to do before, during and after translating, and ends with your first complete translation.

Before you start: ask three questions

A news report for experts and a leaflet for children need different words. The purpose of a translation decides how it should be translated (Nord, 1997). So before you write anything, ask:

1. **Who is the client?** (من هو العميل؟) Clients have their own style and rules.
2. **What is the translation for?** (ما الغرض التواصلي؟) To inform, to persuade, to instruct or to entertain?
3. **Who will read it?** (من هو الجمهور المستهدف؟) Experts or the general public? Adults or children?

The answers are your **translation brief**. If nobody gives you one, ask. If you chose the text yourself, answer the questions yourself.

For example, a short news report translated for KUNA, the Kuwait News Agency, informs English readers interested in Kuwait. So the translation should be formal and neutral, with a short headline.

Next: get to know the text

1. **Read the whole text** once, just to understand it.
2. **Read it again with a pen.** Mark difficult words, idioms, names and numbers.
3. **Find out about the topic** if you do not know it well.
4. **List the key terms** and check them in a dictionary (Chapters 20 and 21).
5. **Picture the translation:** imagine how it should sound. This is your **mental draft**.

While you translate

Break a long text into smaller pieces: paragraphs into sentences, sentences into phrases. Work out what each piece means, then rebuild it in the other language. Keep the links between sentences, such as cause and effect.

Good habits from experienced translators:

- **Be faithful** (الأمانة): do not add or remove meaning. Aim to be faithful, accurate and acceptable to the reader.
- **Write naturally**: the result should usually read as if it had been written in the target language.
- **Tread carefully**: translation is like a minefield (الترجمة كحقل ألغام). Know what is appropriate in both cultures.
- **Translate everything**, including titles, captions and notes. Keep titles short, and do not add to them.
- **Keep it simple**.

After you translate

Always read your translation again, even when you think it is perfect (Chapter 23). Poetry often allows more creative freedom, but informative texts, such as reports and instructions, must be exact. Good translators combine quality and speed, and that builds their reputation.

Your first translation, step by step

Now let us put it all together on one short sentence:

It's raining cats and dogs, so the match has been cancelled.

1. **Plan.** A school is informing Arabic-speaking parents about the match, so the Arabic should be clear and simple.
2. **Understand.** *Raining cats and dogs* is an idiom meaning “raining heavily”. It has nothing to do with animals (Chapter 8).

3. **Write.** A word-by-word version, إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً، لذلك تمّ إلغاء المباراة، makes no sense. A translation of the meaning works: الغيت المباراة بسبب الأمطار الغزيرة.
4. **Check.** Read the Arabic without the English: the meaning is complete and the sentence sounds natural.
5. **Explain,** if you are asked why: “The idiom was translated by its meaning, because a word-for-word version would make no sense to Arabic-speaking readers” (Chapter 25).

You have just translated your first sentence the way professionals do. The rest of the book helps you do each step better.

Try it

1. A hospital asks you to translate a medicine leaflet for its patients. Who is the target audience, and what style should you use?
2. What is the purpose of an advert?
3. Why should you read the whole text before you start translating?

Answers

1. Patients from the general public, so use a clear, simple style with exact words.
2. To persuade.
3. To understand it, find the difficult parts in advance, and form a mental draft.

REMEMBER

- Ask three questions first: **client, purpose, audience**.
- Read the whole text at least twice before you translate.
- Be faithful, write naturally, and always revise.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Client** (العميل): The person or organisation that asks for a translation.
- **Communicative purpose** (الغرض التواصلي): What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain.
- **Target audience** (الجمهور المستهدف): The people who will read the translation.
- **Translation brief** (موجز الترجمة): The client's instructions for a translation: who it is for, what it is for and any other requirements.
- **Mental draft** (المسودة الذهنية): A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text.

Chapter 3: English and Arabic: key differences

Where we are. You know how to prepare a translation. But English and Arabic work differently, and most beginners' mistakes come from these differences. This chapter shows you the main ones, so you can avoid them (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999; Ghazala, 2008).

Step 1: put the sentence in the right order

English usually puts the subject first (Subject–Verb–Object). Formal Arabic often starts with the verb (Verb–Subject–Object), although starting with the subject is also correct. A sentence that starts with a verb is called a **verbal sentence**, and in Arabic it often sounds more natural:

Sam ate the cake. → أكلَ سامٌ الكعكةَ (correct, but less usual) ✓

The government announced new measures. → أعلنت الحكومة إجراءاتٍ جديدة

Length differs too. English often prefers shorter sentences. Arabic often joins several ideas in one long sentence with *و*, *ثم* and *ف*. So join short sentences when you translate into Arabic, and split long ones when you translate into English.

Linking words help your Arabic flow: *غير أنَّ* (however), *لذلك* (therefore), *بالإضافة إلى ذلك* (in addition), *على سبيل المثال* (for example).

Step 2: the small verbs “be”, “do” and “have”

In the present tense, English needs *is* and *are*; Arabic normally leaves them out: *Translation is a fascinating field* → الترجمةُ مجالٌ شائق. In formal writing, *تُعدّ* (“is considered”) is also possible when the sentence gives an opinion: *الترجمة مجالاً شائقاً*. Into English, add the verb: *الطالب في المكتبة* → *The student is in the library.*

Do not translate a simple *is*, *am* or *are* with *يكون*: *She is kind* → إنها طيبة, not هي طيبة; *I am leaving now* → سأغادر الآن. In the past, use *كان*: *The child was sick* → كان الطفل مريضاً.

Do and *have* also need care:

- In negatives and questions, *do* has no Arabic word of its own: *Do not touch it* → لا تلمسه; *She did not eat* → لم تأكل; *Do you want to play?* → هل تريد أن تلعب؟
- As a main verb, *do* has a meaning: *I will do my best* → سأبذل قصارى جهدي.
- The meaning of *have* depends on its object: *She had a nice holiday* → قضت عطلة جميلة; *She had lunch* → تناولت الغداء; *She has money* → تملك مالاً.

Step 3: show gender and number

Each language chooses what its grammar must show, such as gender and number (Baker, 2018). English often leaves these out; Arabic cannot.

- English *you* can be أنت (one man), أنتِ (one woman), أنتم (two people), أنتم (three or more men, or a mixed group) or أنتن (three or more women). Arabic must show gender and number; English need not. In other words, “languages differ essentially in what they must convey and not in what they may convey” (Jakobson, 1959, p. 236).
- With the numbers 3 to 10, the number takes the opposite gender to the singular noun: ثلاث طالبات but ثلاثة طلاب.
- Arabic has a dual (طالبان, two students); English uses *two*.
- English *I* and *you* do not show gender, but Arabic verbs and adjectives do: *I am a student* → أنا طالب or أنا طالبة. If the sentence does not say, look for clues in the whole text: a name, a title such as *Mr* or *Mrs*, a word such as *husband* or *wife*.
- Some feminine job titles have another meaning (نايبة can mean “calamity”; قاضية can mean “fatal”), so some writers avoid them. Today, however, قاضية and نائبة are widely used for women judges and members of parliament.

Step 4: watch out for small words and paired words

Some common English words must not be translated with their first dictionary meaning:

- *He is in bed.* → إنه في فراشه or, depending on context, إنه نائم (rather than إنه (في السرير
- *As an officer, I...* → ...بصفتي ضابطاً; *As the manager of the company, I...* → ...بصفتي مدير الشركة (here *as* means a role, not ك)
- *Shops stay open.* → تظل المحلات التجارية مفتوحة (*stay* means “remain”, not “live”)
- *Eventually* → في نهاية المطاف (it means “in the end”, not “possibly”)
- *...to see the Roman ruins* → لزيارة الآثار الرومانية (Arabic prefers “visit”)

Arabic often places two synonyms side by side for emphasis; English does this much less often. So شجاعٌ مغوار becomes *very brave*, not *brave and daring*.

Step 5: choose the right Arabic and its punctuation

Choose the kind of Arabic that suits the text:

- **Classical Arabic** (العربية الفصحى التراثية): the Arabic of the Qur'an and classical poetry.
- **Modern Standard Arabic** (الفصحى المعاصرة): the Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. Use it for written translation.
- **Dialects** (اللهجات العامية): everyday spoken Arabic. Use one only if the client asks, for example in dubbing a cartoon or a series.

Use Arabic punctuation in Arabic texts: the Arabic comma ,, semicolon ؛ and question mark ؟.

Most translation problems between English and Arabic fall into four groups: **grammar** (النحو), **word choice** (اختيار المفردات), **punctuation and style**, and **general or technical texts**. Style includes how formal the language is: its **register**.

Try it

1. Rewrite as a verbal sentence: الطلاب حضروا المحاضرة.
2. Translate: الطالب في المكتبة.

3. Translate: *He is in bed.*

Answers

1. حضر الطلاب المحاضرة. (When the verb comes first, it stays singular: حضر, not حضروا.)
2. *The student is in the library.*
3. إنه نائم, or, if the context shows he is asleep, إنه في فراشه.

REMEMBER

- **EN → AR:** prefer a verbal sentence, do not translate a simple *is* with يكون, join short sentences, use Arabic punctuation.
- **AR → EN:** start with the subject, split long sentences, turn a pair of synonyms into one expression, add "is".
- Use Modern Standard Arabic unless the client asks for a dialect.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Word order** (ترتيب الكلمات): The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence.
- **Verbal sentence** (الجملة الفعلية): A sentence that starts with a verb.
- **Register** (المستوى اللغوي): How formal or informal the language is.
- **Modern Standard Arabic (MSA)** (الفصحى المعاصرة): The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education.
- **Dialect** (اللهجة العامية): The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region.

Part 2: Understanding meaning

Chapter 4: Form and meaning

Where we are. In Chapter 3 you often changed a sentence's structure. This chapter gives you the rule that makes such changes safe, so you can change the form without losing the meaning.

Step 1: meaning comes first

The shape of a sentence is its **form**; the idea behind it is its **meaning**. In translation we favour meaning over form (المعنى أهم من الشكل): you may change the form, but never the meaning.

Anything said in one language can be said in another, unless the form itself is part of the message, as in a poem's rhyme (Nida & Taber, 1969).

Step 2: change the form when you need to

Copying the English form often gives clumsy Arabic, so change it. For example, a noun can become a verb:

- *He is a heavy smoker.* → يدخن بشراهة (the noun *smoker* becomes the verb يدخن, and the adjective *heavy* becomes بشراهة)
- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل (the noun *arrival* becomes a verb; see Chapter 12)

Step 3: when the image does not travel

Sometimes the problem is a picture. The British press called Tony Blair *Bush's poodle*: someone who obediently follows George Bush. A poodle has no such meaning in Arabic, so the translator keeps the meaning and changes the form: بليز، المنقاد لبوش or تابع بوش.

Try it

1. Translate by changing the form: *He is a fast runner.*

2. Translate by changing the form: *His arrival was late.*

Answers

1. يركض بسرعة.
2. وصل متأخراً.

REMEMBER

- Meaning comes before form.
- You may change the structure, but never the meaning.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Form** (الشكل): The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text.
- **Meaning** (المعنى): The idea that a form expresses.

Chapter 5: Types of meaning

Where we are. Meaning comes before form, but meaning has layers. This chapter shows you three of them, so you can choose words with the right feeling and translate what a speaker really means.

Step 1: same meaning, different feeling

Die and *pass away* say the same thing but feel different. The basic meaning is the **denotation**; the feeling is the **connotation**. These are sometimes called propositional and expressive meaning (Baker, 2018). Choose the word with the right feeling as well as the right meaning:

- *die* (مات) is neutral; *pass away* (تُوفِّي) is polite and respectful; *kick the bucket* is informal and humorous.
- *steed* (جواد) suggests a fine, noble horse; *horse* (حصان) is neutral.
- *friend* (صديق) is general; *comrade* (رفيق) suggests a member of the same party or cause.
- *slim* (رشيق) is positive; *skinny* (هزيل) is negative.

Step 2: what the words say and what the speaker means

أشعرُ بالحرِّ states a fact, but the speaker may mean “Please turn on the air conditioning”. أصبح الجوُّ بارداً may mean “Please turn it off”, and *It’s freezing in here* may mean “Please close the window”.

What the words say is the **sentence meaning**; what the speaker intends is the **speaker meaning**. Translate so that your reader understands what the speaker means. If the indirect sentence works the same way in the target language, keep it indirect.

Step 3: when a single word causes trouble

Some problems appear at the level of the single word (Baker, 2018):

- **No equivalent word:** English has *orphan* and *widow*, but no single word for ثكلى, a mother who has lost a child. This is called a **lexical gap**. Give the meaning: *a bereaved mother*.
- **A false equivalent:** الهنود الحمر is neutral in Arabic, but *Red Indians* is offensive in English. Use *Native Americans*.
- **A rare word:** شبر has an exact English equivalent, *span*, but few readers know it. Use a familiar measure: *about 23 centimetres*.

Try it

1. In an obituary, which is better: مات or تُؤَفِّي?
2. What might a guest mean by saying *It's rather warm in here?*

Answers

1. تُؤَفِّي, because it is respectful.
2. A polite request to open a window or turn on the air conditioning.

REMEMBER

- Check the **connotation** of a word, not only its dictionary meaning.
- Make sure your reader understands what the speaker means, not only what the sentence says.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Denotation** (المعنى المعجمي): The basic, dictionary meaning of a word.
- **Connotation** (المعنى الإيحائي): The extra feeling or association a word carries.
- **Sentence meaning** (معنى الجملة): What the words of a sentence say.
- **Speaker meaning** (مقصد المتكلم): What the speaker really means by saying it.
- **Lexical gap** (الفجوة المعجمية): A concept that has a word in one language but not in the other.

Chapter 6: Context

Where we are. Chapter 5 showed that meaning has layers. Many words also have several meanings. This chapter shows you how to use the words around it, and the wider situation, to choose the right meaning.

Step 1: every situation has its own words

Everything around a word, in the text and outside it, is its **context**. Always pay attention to it. As the Arabic saying goes, لكلِّ مقامٍ مقال: every situation has its own way of speaking.

Step 2: look near, then look far

- **Near:** the words and sentences around a word. This is the **micro context**, or co-text.
- **Far:** the author (for example Nizar Qabbani or Mahmoud Darwish), the audience, the time and place of writing, and the social and historical background. This is the **macro context**.

Picture a triangle with the **author**, the **text** and the **audience** at its three corners. The **translator** stands in the middle and must know all three.

Step 3: use context to choose the right meaning

A word's meanings may be unrelated (**homonymy**) or related (**polysemy**). Either way, context tells you which one is right.

- *bank*: مصرف (for money) or ضفّة النهر (of a river). The meanings are unrelated.
- *case*: حالة (a situation), قضية (an issue or a court case) or علبة (a container, such as a glasses case). The first two meanings are related; the third is not.
- عين: an eye, a water spring or a spy.
- خط: a line, handwriting, a font or a route.
- تطهير: cleaning a wound (تطهير الجرح) or purifying from sins (التطهير من الذنوب). The meanings are related.

- احتجاز: holding water (احتجاز المياه) or holding hostages (احتجاز الرهائن).

Try it

1. Translate *case* in: *The doctor examined the case.*
2. Translate عین in: شربنا من عین ماء باردة.

Answers

1. حالة.
2. *We drank from a cold water spring.*

REMEMBER

- Context decides which meaning is correct.
- Look at the words around a word (micro context) and at the whole situation (macro context).

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Context** (السياق): Everything around a word or text that helps us understand it: the surrounding words and the wider situation.
- **Micro context (co-text)** ((السياق اللغوي (الداخلي)): The words and sentences immediately around a word.
- **Macro context** ((سياق الموقف (الخارجي)): The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text.
- **Homonymy** (المشترك اللفظي): One word with several meanings that are not related.
- **Polysemy** (تعدد المعنى): One word with several meanings that are related.

Part 3: Words that go together

Chapter 7: Collocation

Where we are. Some words appear together so often that they become partners. This chapter shows you how to recognise these partners and translate them naturally.

Step 1: notice the company a word keeps

Words that naturally go together form a **collocation**. It has been defined as “the company a word keeps” (Translation Team, n.d.). The idea comes from linguistics: “You shall know a word by the company it keeps” (Firth, 1957, p. 11). Each language has its own partners, so a collocation often cannot be translated word by word (Baker, 2018).

The basic meaning of *pay* is to give money, but its partners change its meaning:

- *pay money* → يدفع المال (the basic meaning)
- *pay attention* → يُعير انتباهه or ينتبهه (يدفع الانتباه)
- *pay respect* → يُبدي احتراماً
- *pay a visit* → يقوم بزيارة (يدفع زيارة)

Step 2: find a new verb for each partner

One English verb may need a different Arabic verb with each partner:

- *deliver a letter* → يسلم رسالة; *deliver a speech* → يلقي خطاباً
- *deliver the news* → ينقل الخبر; *deliver a blow* → يوجّه ضربة; *deliver a verdict* → يُصدر حكماً

Step 3: practise in both directions

EN → AR

- *close cooperation* → تعاون وثيق; *a close friend* → صديق مقرب
- *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل (not شاي قوي)
- *a fast colour* → لون ثابت; *a fast friend* → صديق وفّي
- *break the law* → يخالف القانون (more natural than يكسر القانون)

AR → EN

- استل سيفه → *he drew his sword*
- يساورني القلق → *I am worried*
- قدّم استقالته → *he resigned*
- اتخذ قراراً → *he made a decision*
- عقد اجتماعاً → *he held a meeting*

Try it

1. Translate: *heavy rain*
2. Translate: *deliver a lecture*
3. Translate: عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً

Answers

1. (مطر ثقيل (not مطر غزير).
2. يلقي محاضرة (like *deliver a speech*).
3. *He held a press conference.*

REMEMBER

- Learn words **with their partners**.
- Translate a collocation with the natural partner in the other language.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Collocation** (التلازم اللفظي): Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps.

Chapter 8: Idioms, proverbs and fixed expressions

Where we are. Some word partners go further than collocations: they are fixed, and together they mean something new. This chapter shows you how to recognise and translate them.

Step 1: recognise an idiom

It's a piece of cake means “it is easy”. This is an **idiom**. Its words are frozen: you usually cannot change their order or replace one of them.

A **fixed expression** is frozen too, but its meaning is clear from its words: *as a matter of fact* → في واقع الأمر; *ladies and gentlemen* → سيداتي سادتي; *all the best* → مع أطيب التمنيات. Use the expression that the target language uses in the same situation.

How to spot an idiom:

- It makes no literal sense: *It's raining cats and dogs*.
- It breaks the rules of grammar: *by and large* (“in general”).
- It is a comparison with *like*: *like two peas in a pod* (“very similar”).
- If an expression makes little sense in its context, it is probably an idiom.

Step 2: check the context first

The same words can sometimes be meant literally. *A piece of cake* usually means “easy” (سهل جداً), but at a birthday party it may simply mean قطعة من الكعكة.

Step 3: choose one of five ways

Here are five common ways (Baker, 2018). As a rule, try them in this order, but let the context decide:

1. An idiom with the same meaning and the same form, if one exists: *to play with fire* → يلعب بالنار.

2. An idiom with the same meaning but a different form: *It's raining cats and dogs* → تمطر كأفواه القرب.
3. Borrowing the idiom, when readers will understand it.
4. A paraphrase: the meaning in plain words.
5. Omission, only when the idiom adds nothing and cannot be translated.

Some English idioms:

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → تمطر بغزارة
- *to roll up one's sleeves* → شَمَّر عن ساعديه
- *over the moon* → في قَمَّة السعادة
- *to spill the beans* → أفضى السرَّ
- *I'm all ears.* → كَلِّي آذانٌ صاغية
- *Break a leg!* → بالتوفيق!
- *Mark my words.* → تذكّر كلامي
- *to hit the sack* → أوى إلى فراشه
- *to bury the hatchet* → طوى صفحة الخلاف
- *in a nutshell* → باختصار
- *the long and the short of it* → خلاصة القول
- *Don't put words in my mouth.* → لا تتقول عليّ

Step 4: translate proverbs

For a **proverb**, look for one with the same meaning in the other language. If there is none, give the meaning in plain words:

- *out of the frying pan into the fire* → كالمستجير من الرمضاء بالنار
- *he came back empty-handed* → رجع بخفّي حنين
- *a bird in the hand is worth two in the bush* → عصفورٌ في اليد خيرٌ من عشرةٍ على الشجرة

- *Boys will be boys.* → الولد ولد ولو صار قاضي بلد (a colloquial proverb)
- *Business is business.* → تعاشرُوا كالإخوة وتعاملُوا كالأجانب

Try it

1. Translate: *It's a piece of cake.* (about an exam)
2. Translate: *to spill the beans*
3. Translate: رجع بخُفِّي حُنين.

Answers

1. الامتحان سهل جداً.
2. أفشى السرّ.
3. *He came back empty-handed.*

REMEMBER

- Do not translate an idiom word by word unless the other language has the same idiom.
- First check that the expression really is an idiom in this context.
- For proverbs, look for an equivalent proverb; if there is none, give the meaning.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Idiom** (التعبير الاصطلاحي): A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words.
- **Proverb** (المثل): A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth.
- **Fixed expression** (العبارة المسكوكة): A fixed group of words whose meaning is clear from its words, such as *as a matter of fact*.

Part 4: Methods and techniques

Chapter 9: Equivalence

Where we are. Chapter 8 showed that idioms often lack an exact Arabic match. Here are three ways to translate them, and which to try first.

Step 1: one sentence, three choices

The agreement has remained a dead letter since then. A “dead letter” is an agreement that exists on paper but is never applied. You can translate it in three ways, the three types of **equivalence** (Farghal & Shunnaq, 1999):

- **Formal:** وقد بقيت الاتفاقية حرفاً ميتاً منذ ذلك الوقت. The words are correct, but many Arab readers will not recognise the image.
- **Functional:** بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق منذ ذلك الوقت. A familiar Arabic idiom: the best choice here.
- **Ideational:** لم تُطبَّق الاتفاقية منذ ذلك الوقت. Clear, but the colour of the idiom is lost.

Note: *agreement* is اتفاقية and *treaty* is معاهدة. Keep the difference.

Step 2: more examples

- *You should think outside the box.* Formal: عليك أن تفكر خارج الصندوق (now used in Arabic too). Ideational: عليك أن تفكر بطريقة إبداعية.
- *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* Functional: علي لا يُشَقُّ له غبار في كتابة الشعر. Ideational: علي لا يُضاهى في كتابة الشعر.

Step 3: which to try first

Try formal equivalence first. If it does not work, look for a functional equivalent. If there is none, give the idea.

The goal is “the closest natural equivalent of the source-language message, first in terms of meaning and secondly in terms of style” (Nida & Taber, 1969, p. 12).

Try it

1. Which type? *Ali is second to none in writing poetry.* → علي لا يُضاهى في كتابة الشعر
2. Give a functional equivalent: *The agreement remained a dead letter.*

Answers

1. Ideational: only the basic idea is kept.
2. بقيت الاتفاقية حبراً على ورق.

REMEMBER

- There are three types of equivalence: formal, functional and ideational.
- Choose the one that gives the closest natural meaning for your reader.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression.
- **Formal equivalence** (التكافؤ الشكلي): Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb.
- **Functional equivalence** (التكافؤ الوظيفي): Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form.
- **Ideational equivalence** (التكافؤ الفكري): Giving only the basic idea, in plain words.

Chapter 10: Literal and free translation

Where we are. Now you will make the choice from Chapter 9 for a whole text: follow the words, or the message. You will learn when each works.

Step 1: following the words

You can keep the words, changing only what grammar requires. This is **literal translation**. It can be either successful or destructive (قد تكون الترجمة الحرفية (ناجحة أو مدمرة). It works only when the target language has the same expression:

- *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً ✓
- *to pay a visit* → يدفع زيارة ✗ (يقوم بزيارة)
- *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً طويلاً ✗ (in English, a long day is a tiring one)
- *What are you wearing on your biggest day?* (in a wedding advert) → ماذا سترتدي في أكبر يوم لديك؟ ✗ (ماذا سترتدي في يوم زفافك؟)

Step 2: following the message

Or you can keep the message and change the form. This is **free translation**, used for all kinds of texts, not only literary works. Compare:

- *Appointing new employees should be done on the basis of equal opportunity.* → يجب تعيين الموظفين الجدد بعيداً عن المحسوبية والواسطة والمحاباة. A free translation that keeps the message.
- *Going out can be risky these days.* → a translator who knows the context (for example, the Covid-19 pandemic) might write a sentence about the virus spreading.
- *We have had heavy rainfall this winter.* → ينتظرنا هذا العام موسمٌ زراعيٌّ مبشّر بالخير.
- *His parents are not quite happy about what he said to them.* → a sentence about respecting one's parents.

Step 3: how free is too free?

The freer the translation, the greater the risk of adding meaning. The last three examples are very free: they add an interpretation or a new idea. Translation this free comes close to **adaptation**.

The principle of translating “not word for word but sense for sense” is very old (Jerome, 395/2012), and some of the great Abbasid translators, such as Hunayn ibn Ishaq, followed it too (Baker & Hanna, 2009). As a beginner, translate the meaning, but do not add ideas.

Try it

1. Is this literal translation successful? *to play a role* → يلعب دوراً
2. Correct: *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً طويلاً

Answers

1. Yes: Arabic uses the same expression.
2. لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.

REMEMBER

- Literal translation works only when the target language has the same expression.
- Free translation may change the form, but it should not add new ideas.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): Keeping the original words, changing only what grammar requires; also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة).
- **Free translation** (الترجمة الحرة): Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation.
- **Adaptation (method)** (التكييف): A very free rewriting; some specialists see it as a new text, not a translation.

Chapter 11: Metaphoric translation

Where we are. Literal translation (Chapter 10) often fails with images. Here you will learn to spot and translate metaphors and similes.

Step 1: spot the comparison

Comparing things to create a picture is one kind of **figurative language**. A comparison with *as* or *like* is a **simile**: *He is as brave as a lion*. Without them, it is a **metaphor**: *He is a lion*. Poetry is especially rich in metaphors.

Step 2: how Arabic sees it

Arabic rhetoric draws the line differently: *هو أسد* is a concise simile (تشبيه بليغ), because both sides of the comparison are named. A استعارة names only the image, as in رأيت أسداً يخطب.

Step 3: translating a metaphor

Follow these steps in order, based on four of the seven standard procedures for translating metaphors (Newmark, 1988):

1. **If the metaphor is shared** by both languages, translate it literally. *She is a snake.* → إنها أفعى. *My hopes evaporated.* → تبخرت آمالي. *My paper will see the light of day next December.* → سترى ورقتي البحثية النور في ديسمبر المقبل.
2. **If it is not shared**, replace it with a target-language image with the same meaning. *This is the tip of the iceberg.* → هذا غيض من فيض, or, when something bad is hidden, وما خفي كان أعظم.
3. **Or turn it into a simile**: *He is a rock.* → إنه كالصخرة في ثباته.
4. **If nothing works**, give the basic meaning. This is the last choice, because the image is lost. *The news raised a few eyebrows.* → أثار الخبر استغراب بعضهم.

Try it

1. Translate: *My hopes evaporated.*
2. Translate: *This is only the tip of the iceberg.* (about a scandal)

Answers

1. تبخّرت آمالي.
2. هذا غيظٌ من فيضٍ or وما خفي كان أعظم.

REMEMBER

- Keep a shared image; replace an unshared one; turn it into a simile; give the plain meaning as a last choice.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Figurative language** (اللغة المجازية): Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect.
- **Metaphor** (الاستعارة): A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning.
- **Simile** (التشبيه): A comparison that uses “as” or “like”.

Chapter 12: The seven translation procedures

Where we are. Chapters 9 to 11 dealt with whole texts and expressions. Now you will learn seven precise techniques for smaller units, and spot them in a translation.

Step 1: methods and procedures

Literal and free translation are **methods**. Smaller units need **translation procedures**: “while translation methods relate to whole texts, translation procedures are used for sentences and the smaller units of language” (Newmark, 1988, p. 81).

Step 2: the seven procedures

There are seven (Vinay & Darbelnet, 1958/1995), each further from the original:

1. **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): *computer* → كمبيوتر
2. **Calque** (النسخ): *skyscraper* → ناطحة سحاب
3. **Literal translation** (الترجمة الحرفية): *The book is on the table.* → الكتاب على الطاولة
4. **Transposition** (الإبدال): *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل
5. **Modulation** (التطويع): *It is not difficult.* → إنه سهل
6. **Equivalence** (التكافؤ): *Like father, like son.* → هذا الشبل من ذاك الأسد
7. **Adaptation** (التكييف): *They are like Romeo and Juliet.* → هما كقيس وليلى

Step 3: direct or oblique?

The first three, which stay close to the original, are **direct** procedures; the last four are **oblique**. Use a direct procedure when it gives an accurate, natural result; otherwise, choose an oblique one. Borrowing is used mainly to fill a gap or to keep local colour.

Step 4: one sentence, several procedures

After his arrival in Kuwait, the minister held a press conference at the Sheraton and said the reforms were not impossible.

بعد أن وصل الوزير إلى الكويت، عقد مؤتمراً صحفياً في فندق شيراتون، وقال إنَّ الإصلاحات ممكنة.

- *after his arrival* → بعد أن وصل: transposition
- *press conference* → مؤتمر صحفي: calque
- *Sheraton* → فندق شيراتون: borrowing, plus the added word فندق (addition, Chapter 13)
- *not impossible* → ممكنة: modulation

Try it

1. Which procedure? *email* → إيميل
2. Which procedure? *honeymoon* → شهر العسل
3. Which procedure? *It is not easy.* → إنه صعب

Answers

1. Borrowing.
2. Calque.
3. Modulation.

REMEMBER

- Procedures 1–3 are direct; 4–7 are oblique.
- Learn their names: you will use them in your commentary (Chapter 25).

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation procedure** (إجراء الترجمة): A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence.
- **Borrowing** (الاقتراض): Taking a word from the source language as it is.
- **Calque** (النسخ): Translating each part of an expression literally; also called loan translation (Chapter 16).
- **Transposition** (الإبدال): Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb.
- **Modulation** (التطويع): Expressing the same idea from another point of view.
- **Equivalence (procedure)** (التكافؤ): Describing the same situation with a completely different expression, often an idiom or a proverb; narrower than equivalence in general (Chapter 9).
- **Adaptation (procedure)** (التكييف): Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one; smaller in scale than adaptation as a method (Chapter 10).

Chapter 13: Translation strategies

Where we are. Some problems need a wider plan than the procedures of Chapter 12. Here you will learn the main strategies.

Step 1: the closest solutions

A planned solution to a translation problem is called a **translation strategy** (Translation Team, n.d.; Baker, 2018). Begin with the closest ones:

1. **Literal and idiomatic translation:** translating literally when the result is natural, and translating an idiom with another idiom when possible. Check the field even for simple terms: *key word* can be كلمة مفتاحية or كلمة دالة, depending on the field.
2. **Functional translation:** *a dead letter* → حبرٌ على ورق; *second to none* → لا يُشَقَّ له غبار. When there is no matching expression, give the plain meaning, as in ideational equivalence (Chapter 9): *spill the beans* → أفشى السرّ; *mark my words* → تذكّر كلامي.
3. **Cultural substitution** (adaptation, Chapter 12): *They are like Romeo and Juliet*. → هما كقيس وليلى. Measures can also follow the reader's culture: *5 miles* → نحو 8 كيلومترات.

Step 2: add, remove or explain

1. **Addition:** common from English into Arabic, because Arabic style often favours fuller expression (الإطناب), and Arab readers may need information that English readers already have. *the Fed* → مجلس الاحتياطي الفيدرالي الأمريكي.
2. **Omission:** common from Arabic into English, where repeated synonyms sound unnatural. شجاعٌ مغوار → *very brave*. It is also used to avoid words that would offend the reader. Never omit real information.
3. **Explanatory translation:** use it only when nothing shorter works, because it makes the text longer. It suits cultural and religious terms such as الزكاة and العِدَّة, and for dense technical terms (Chapter 15).

Step 3: no exact word

Translators also use these strategies; the first four come from Baker (2018):

1. **A more general word:** when the target language has no exact word. *prawns* and *shrimps* → روبيان.
2. **A more neutral word:** when the source word carries a feeling that would sound wrong in the target text.
3. **Paraphrase:** explaining the meaning in other words. *jet lag* → الإرهاق الناتج عن فارق التوقيت.
4. **Loan word plus explanation:** explain the word the first time, then use it alone: *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam). English has also borrowed many Arabic words: *algebra*, *algorithm*, *hijab*.
5. **Compensation:** if a pun or a rhyme is lost in one sentence, create a similar effect elsewhere (Dickins et al., 2016).

Step 4: how local should the text feel?

For the text as a whole, **domestication** makes it feel local to the reader, and **foreignisation** keeps its foreign flavour (Venuti, 1995). For example, in an English text, الديوانية can become *a men's evening gathering* (domestication) or stay *the diwaniya* (foreignisation). Let the brief decide (Chapter 2).

Try it

1. Which strategy? شجاعٌ مِغوار → *very brave*
2. Which strategy? *Romeo and Juliet* → قيس وليلى
3. Why is addition common from English into Arabic?

Answers

1. Omission.
2. Cultural substitution.
3. Because Arabic style often favours fuller expression, and Arab readers may need extra information.

REMEMBER

- Choose the right strategy for each problem; do not use the same one everywhere.
- Use explanatory translation only when nothing shorter works.
- Decide, with the brief, whether the text should feel local or foreign.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation strategy** (استراتيجية الترجمة): A planned solution to a translation problem.
- **Functional translation** (الترجمة الوظيفية): Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function.
- **Cultural substitution** (الاستبدال الثقافي): Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader.
- **Addition** (الإضافة): Adding words or information that the reader needs.
- **Omission** (الحذف): Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language.
- **Explanatory translation** (الترجمة الشرحية): Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent.
- **Compensation** (التعويض): Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere.
- **Domestication** (التوطين): Making a translation feel local to the target reader.
- **Foreignisation** (التغريب): Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text.

Part 5: Culture and new words

Chapter 14: Cultural approximation

Where we are. A translation is never a perfect copy (Chapter 1), and culture makes this harder still. This chapter shows you how to bring cultural meaning close to your reader.

Step 1: translate the feeling, not the picture

I have got the test in the bag is not about a bag: the speaker is sure of success. Arabic says this with a different picture. When a picture carries a different feeling in the other culture, keep the feeling. This is called **cultural approximation**, and it needs a good knowledge of both cultures.

Often Arabic already has an expression with the same effect:

- *I have got the test in the bag.* → الامتحان في جيبِي (informal: it is guaranteed)
- *Like mother, like daughter.* → اقلب الجرّة على فمها تطلع البنت لأُمّها (a colloquial proverb; in a formal text, give the meaning: البنت تُشبه أُمّها)
- *Ali and Ahmad are cut from the same cloth.* → عليّ وأحمد من طينة واحدة
- *a scapegoat* → كبش فداء
- *to sleep like a log* → نام كالقتيل
- *as busy as a bee* → نشيط كالنحلة

Step 2: when the climate changes the meaning

In a hot climate, relief and joy are linked with coolness. So *The news warmed my heart* becomes أُلجّ الخبرُ صدري. Likewise, a translator of Shakespeare's line "Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?" (Shakespeare, 1609) may choose spring for Arab readers: أَشَبّهك بيوم ربيعِي؟

Step 3: titles, institutions and business words

Titles and offices are **culture-specific items**: each country names them in its own way. Translate the job, not the words:

- *the Home Office* (UK) → وزارة الداخلية البريطانية
- *the Chancellor of the Exchequer* (UK) → وزير المالية البريطاني
- *the Secretary of the Treasury* (US) → وزير الخزانة الأمريكي
- *the Secretary of State* (US) → وزير الخارجية الأمريكي
- *sheriff* (US) → رئيس شرطة المقاطعة

Media and business words, too:

- *watchdog press* → الصحافة الرقابية; *lapdog press* → الصحافة الموالية
- *mocktail* (a drink without alcohol) → مشروب مُنعش بلا كحول
- *product cannibalisation* (a new product takes sales from another product of the same company) → مزاحمة منتج جديد لمنتج آخر للشركة نفسها

Step 4: say what people really say

Use the phrase people actually say in the same situation, in the variety of Arabic that suits your reader:

- *God willing.* → إن شاء الله
- *We are very well.* → الحمد لله، بخير
- *Welcome! It is an honour to have you here.* → أهلاً وسهلاً، شَرَفْتُمُونَا
- *I am sorry for your loss.* → عَظُمَ اللهُ أَجْرَكُمْ (formal); in Egyptian Arabic, البقية في حياتك
- *Thank you for your hard work.* → يعطيك العافية (Gulf and Levantine spoken Arabic)

Try it

1. Translate: *cut from the same cloth*
2. Translate: *the Secretary of State* (US)
3. Why does *warm* my heart become *أثلج صدري*?

Answers

1. من طينة واحدة.
2. وزير الخارجية الأمريكي.
3. In a hot climate, relief is linked with coolness, not warmth.

REMEMBER

- Translate the effect, not the image.
- Use what a target-language speaker would say in the same situation.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Cultural approximation** (التقريب الثقافي): Bringing the source text's cultural meaning as close as possible to the target reader.
- **Culture-specific item** (عنصر ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture.

Chapter 15: Descriptive translation

Where we are. In Chapter 14, the other language had a similar expression ready. Sometimes it has no word and no similar custom. This chapter shows you how to explain such a word.

Step 1: when there is nothing to match

English has no exact word for الزكاة, and no identical custom. So you describe the meaning. This is called **descriptive translation**:

1. **Transliterate** the source word, for example *zakat*.
2. **Describe** its meaning, in brackets after the word or in a footnote.
3. Describe it **only the first time**. After that, the transliterated word is enough.

Step 2: see it done

- الزكاة → *zakat* (obligatory annual alms in Islam: a fixed share of savings and wealth above a minimum amount, given to those in need)
- التيمم → *tayammum* (dry ritual purification: wiping the face and hands with clean earth when water is missing or cannot be used)
- البسملة → *the basmala* (saying “In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful”)
- الحوقلة → *the hawqala* (saying “There is no might and no power except by God”)
- العدة → *idda* (the waiting period before a divorced or widowed woman may remarry)
- العطوة → *atwa* (a temporary truce in tribal customary law, for example in Jordan)
- *Ali has been sectioned.* (UK) → أودع عليّ مستشفى للأمراض النفسية بموجب القانون

Step 3: know when to use it

When readers do not need the source word, give the description alone, as in the last example. Use descriptive translation as your last option, because it makes the text longer. It suits cultural words and complex technical terms.

Try it

1. Translate for English readers: الوقف
2. Where can you put the description?

Answers

1. *waqf* (a charitable endowment in Islam).
2. In brackets after the word, or in a footnote.

REMEMBER

- Transliterate first, then describe.
- Describe only the first time a word appears.
- Use it as the last option.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Descriptive translation** (الترجمة الوصفية): Paraphrasing a source expression by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation (الترجمة الشرحية, Chapter 13).
- **Transliteration** (النقل الصوتي): Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language.
- **Concept** (المفهوم): An idea that a word or term stands for.

Chapter 16: Lexical creation

Where we are. When a word is needed again and again, a long explanation (Chapter 15) is not practical, and the language needs a new word. This chapter shows you how translators make one, and why you should search first.

Step 1: why new words are needed

Some cultural, religious, political or technical concepts have no equivalent, because the target language has a gap in its vocabulary. The translator then has to coin a word. This is called **lexical creation**.

Step 2: five ways to make a word

1. **Neologism:** a new word, often derived from an Arabic root (الاشتقاق), or an old word with a new meaning. *blog* → مدونة (from دَوَّن, “to write down”)
2. **Loan translation (calque):** *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي; *shadow government* → حكومة الظل; *Thanksgiving* → عيد الشكر
3. **Transliteration** (borrowing), with a short definition the first time: الصكوك → *sukuk* (Islamic investment certificates). Into Arabic, this is called Arabicisation (التعريب): *radio* → الراديو; *strategy* → استراتيجية; *technology* → تكنولوجيا
4. **Explanation:** a term that explains the idea instead of copying the parts (“green” + “washing”): *greenwashing* → التضليل البيئي (companies falsely claiming that their products are environmentally friendly)
5. **Hybrid form:** part translated, part borrowed. *cybersecurity* → الأمن السيبراني

Arabic can also blend two words into one, called النحت: *amphibious* → برمائي (برّ + ماء).

Step 3: search before you create

First search for an accepted term. The Arabic language academies, UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.) record many new terms. For example: *global warming* → الاحترار العالمي; *greenhouse effect* → الاحتباس الحراري; *cancel culture* → ثقافة الإلغاء.

An accepted term is always better than a new invention. When a new word becomes widely accepted and enters the dictionary, it is **lexicalised** (المُعْجَمَة).

Try it

1. Which method? *smartphone* → الهاتف الذكي
2. What should you do before creating a new word?

Answers

1. Loan translation (calque).
2. Search for an accepted term in the academies, UNTERM or Arabterm.

REMEMBER

- Create a new word only when no accepted term exists.
- The five methods: neologism, calque, transliteration, explanation and hybrid form.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Lexical creation** (التوليد المعجمي): Coining new target-language words for items with no direct equivalent.
- **Neologism** (اللفظ المستحدث): A new word, or an existing word given a new meaning.
- **Loan translation (calque)** (النسخ): Translating the parts of a compound word one by one.

Part 6: Working with whole texts

Chapter 17: Text analysis

Where we are. So far you have worked with words and sentences. Now you move to whole texts. This chapter gives you a checklist for studying any text before you translate it.

Step 1: why study the text first?

Studying a text before translating it is called **text analysis** (Nord, 2005). It is the first of three phases: analysis, translation and commentary (Chapter 25). It helps you in several ways:

- Each new reading brings new ideas.
- You identify the field, the source and target audiences, the time, purpose, tone and genre.
- You find difficult terms early, so you translate faster.
- You choose your strategies and see what resources you need.
- You form a mental draft of the translation.

Begin “by reading the original for two purposes: first, to understand what it is about; second, to analyse it from a ‘translator’s’ point of view” (Newmark, 1988, p. 11).

Step 2: analyse, do not summarise

A **summary** gives only the facts. An **analysis** looks at who wrote the text, for whom, why and how. When asked to analyse, do not summarise.

Step 3: use the checklist

Answer these questions for every text:

1. Who is the author or speaker?
2. Who published it?

3. What is the field?
4. What is the genre and the purpose?
5. What is the tone, and what is the style of writing?
6. Who is the target audience?
7. Which terms and words need checking?
8. Which strategies will you use?

For example, take a short KUNA news report about relations between Kuwait and Australia. **Field:** politics. **Genre and purpose:** news report, to inform. **Tone:** neutral and straightforward. **Publisher:** KUNA. **Audience:** readers interested in Kuwait and the Middle East. **Style:** formal, with no short forms. **Strategy:** mostly literal, because the text has no metaphors.

Step 4: let the analysis guide you

A good analyst:

- keeps training their analytical skills;
- builds a personal model of analysis;
- makes the translation match the analysis: a formal tone means a formal translation;
- notes the text's problems, so the commentary can explain the solutions.

Try it

1. What is the difference between an analysis and a summary?
2. Name the three phases of translation.

Answers

1. A summary gives the facts; an analysis describes the features, background, purpose and style.
2. Analysis, translation and commentary.

REMEMBER

- Analyse **before** you translate.
- Your translation must match your analysis.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Text** (النص): Any piece of language, written or spoken, that forms a complete message: from a one-word sign to a whole book.
- **Text analysis** (تحليل النص): Breaking down and studying a text before translating it.
- **Genre** (الجنس النصي): A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report, a contract or a poem.
- **Tone** (النبرة): The writer's attitude, for example neutral, critical or friendly.
- **Field** (المجال): The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law.

Chapter 18: Text types and genres

Where we are. In Chapter 17 you learned to name a text's genre. This chapter shows you why the genre matters, with an example of each main genre.

Step 1: what is the text for?

Texts can be grouped by their main function (Reiss, 1971/2000). **Informative** texts give facts, **expressive** texts are creative and focus on form, as in literature, and **operative** texts persuade.

Step 2: each genre has its own rules

- **News:** facts, neutral tone and short headlines. *Oil prices rose sharply on Monday.* → ارتفعت أسعار النفط ارتفاعاً حاداً يوم الاثنين.
- **Legal:** exact words; *shall* expresses an obligation or a legal rule. *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* → تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت.
- **Political:** careful, sensitive words. *The two sides held frank and constructive talks.* → أجرى الجانبان محادثات صريحة وبنّاءة.
- **Medical:** no ambiguity and exact doses. *Take one tablet twice daily.* → تناول قرصاً واحداً مرتين يومياً.
- **Technical:** clear instructions and consistent terms. *Press and hold the power button.* → اضغط مطوّلاً على زرّ التشغيل.
- **Literary:** feeling, voice and natural dialogue. *It has been a long day.* → لقد كان يوماً شاقاً.
- **Poetry:** images and rhythm, with more freedom. *The horses, the night and the desert know me.* (al-Mutanabbi, n.d.) → الخيلُ والليلُ والبيداءُ تعرفني.
- **Advertising:** persuasion and rhythm. *Save more. Smile more.* → وقر أكثر...! وابتسم أكثر!

Step 3: translating news

English headlines have their own grammar:

- No *a, the* or *is*. A passive headline often becomes a verbal noun (مصدر) in Arabic: *Man killed, woman wounded in shooting* → مقتل رجل وإصابة امرأة في إطلاق نار.
- The simple present reports a recent event: *Minister opens new hospital* → الوزير يفتتح مستشفى جديداً.
- *to + verb* means the future: *Saudi Arabia to extend visas for expats* → السعودية ستمدد تأشيرات الوافدين.
- Add what Arab readers may not know: *Mustang customer complaint* → شكوى زبون من سيارة فورد موستانج.

Most news stories give the most important facts first, in the headline and the first paragraph (the lead), and the details follow. This is the **inverted pyramid**. Keep this order in your translation.

Hard news reports facts, such as decisions, disasters and discoveries, without the writer's opinion. **Soft news** tells human stories, to interest or move the reader.

Step 4: technical and literary texts

In technical texts, one word can be a different term in each field: *depression* is الاكتئاب in psychology, الكساد in economics and منخفض جوي in a weather report. Check the field every time (Chapter 21).

In literary texts, **style** matters as much as content: word choice, sentence length, tone and dialogue. If a character speaks in dialect to show who they are, find a way to keep that effect.

Try it

1. Which text type is an advert: informative, expressive or operative?
2. Why does a medical text need exact words?

Answers

1. Operative: it tries to persuade.
2. Because a mistake, such as a wrong dose, can harm the reader.

REMEMBER

- Identify the genre before you translate.
- Follow the rules of the same genre in the target language.
- News headlines have their own grammar; translate them into natural Arabic headlines.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Text type** (نمط النص): A group of texts that share one main function: to inform, to express or to persuade.
- **Genre** (الجنس النصي): A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report or a recipe.
- **Headline** (العنوان الرئيسي): The title of a news story.
- **Inverted pyramid** (الهرم المقلوب): A news structure that gives the most important facts first.

Chapter 19: Words and points of view

Where we are. After genre (Chapter 18), look for the writer's point of view, often hidden in single words. Three simple questions will help you find it.

Step 1: words are rarely neutral

Many word choices show a point of view, shaped by the writer's **ideology**, and your translation can keep, soften or strengthen it. A word that carries a judgement is a **loaded word**. Follow the client's policy on sensitive words (Chapter 2).

- *A suicide bomber killed ten people.* → انتحاري matches the English; استشهادي adds praise. The same person is seen from opposite points of view, so follow the client's policy.
- *regime or government* (حكومة or نظام): in political texts, "regime" is negative.
- *Protesters were killed.* (قُتل متظاهرون): the passive hides who did the killing.

Step 2: ask three questions

Language is connected to power and society (Fairclough, 1992). This gives you three questions:

1. **The words:** which words show a judgement? Who is shown doing what, and who is hidden?
2. **The writer:** who wrote the text, for which newspaper or organisation, and for which readers?
3. **The purpose:** whose interests does the text serve?

Try it

1. Why is *regime* not neutral?
2. What does the passive in *Protesters were killed* hide?

Answers

1. It suggests a harsh or illegitimate government.
2. Who did the killing.

REMEMBER

- Notice loaded words and hidden doers.
- Follow the client's policy, and explain sensitive choices in your commentary (Chapter 25).

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Ideology** (الأيدولوجيا): A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events.
- **Loaded word** (كلمة مشحونة): A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative.

Part 7: Tools and resources

Chapter 20: Printed and digital dictionaries

Where we are. In Chapter 2 you checked key terms in a dictionary. This chapter shows you which dictionaries to use, and how to choose the right meaning.

Step 1: a dictionary gives options, not answers

A famous saying goes: “Dictionaries are like watches; the worst is better than none, and the best cannot be expected to go quite true” (Johnson, 1784/1897, p. 309). So do not simply take the first meaning. Use the three-check rule:

1. Find the options in a **bilingual dictionary**.
2. Confirm the meaning in a **monolingual dictionary**.
3. See how the word is really used in a text written in the target language.

For example, for *a fast colour* a bilingual dictionary gives سريع and ثابت. An Arabic dictionary confirms that ثابت can mean “not fading”, and clothing labels use لون ثابت. So the answer is لون ثابت.

Step 2: printed or digital?

- **Printed dictionaries:** edited by experts, with full entries and examples, but slower to use, and they may lack new words.
- **Digital dictionaries:** fast and often updated, but quality varies. Check the publisher: a digital version of a known printed dictionary is safer than an unknown website.

Step 3: dictionaries to start with

- *Al-Mawrid* (Baalbaki, n.d.): English–Arabic, for general words.
- *A Dictionary of Modern Written Arabic* (Wehr, 1994): Arabic–English, with words listed by root.

- *Al-Mu'jam al-Wasīṭ* (المعجم الوسيط) (Academy of the Arabic Language in Cairo, n.d.): a monolingual Arabic dictionary from the Academy in Cairo.
- *Oxford Collocations Dictionary for Students of English* (2009): natural English word partners.
- UNTERM (United Nations, n.d.) and Arabterm (ALECSO & GIZ, n.d.): official and technical terms. For one field, such as law or medicine, add a **specialised dictionary**.

Try it

1. Which dictionary do you use to confirm a meaning?
2. What should you check before trusting a digital dictionary?

Answers

1. A monolingual dictionary.
2. Who publishes it.

REMEMBER

- Check a bilingual dictionary, then a monolingual one, then a real text.
- Use printed and digital dictionaries together; check digital sources.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Bilingual dictionary** (معجم ثنائي اللغة): A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language.
- **Monolingual dictionary** (معجم أحادي اللغة): A dictionary that explains words in the same language.
- **Specialised dictionary** (معجم متخصص): A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine.
- **Collocations dictionary** (معجم المتلازمات اللفظية): A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language.

Chapter 21: Terminology and terminology management

Where we are. In Chapter 20 you learned to use dictionaries. This chapter looks at the special words of each field. By the end, you will be able to find, record and use them consistently.

Step 1: spot the special words in a text

In a contract or a medical leaflet, some words have one exact meaning in that field. These are **terms**. One wrong term can change the meaning of a contract or a medical instruction.

The study of how terms are collected, named and managed is called **terminology** (Cabr , 1999).

Terms often appear in short forms. Learn to recognise four kinds:

- **Initialism:** letters read one by one: *CIA*, *CBC* (complete blood count).
- **Acronym:** letters read as a word: *LASER*.
- **Abbreviation:** part of a word: *vol.* (volume).
- **Clipping:** a word cut short, often keeping its first part: *super* (superintendent).

Step 2: know who looks after terms

- A **translator** works across two languages and uses terms from glossaries, dictionaries and termbases.
- A **terminologist** studies the terms of a field rather than whole texts: they collect, record and sometimes standardise them, in one or more languages.

For Arabic, the Arabic language academies (مجامع اللغة العربية), for example in Damascus, Cairo, Baghdad and Amman, create and approve terms (Translation Team, n.d.). The Coordination Bureau of Arabization in Rabat (مكتب تنسيق التعريب) helps to unify them across the Arab world.

Step 3: translate a term

1. **Understand** its exact meaning in its field. In a medical text, *allergic* is أَرَجِيّ (everyday Arabic often says تحسّسي), an *allergen* is مادة مُحسّسة, and *contact eczema* is إكزيما التماس.
2. **Look at its origin:** its parts often explain it.
3. **Find the equivalent:** check the client's guide first, then the academies' term lists, UNTERM and Arabterm.
4. **If none exists**, think like a terminologist and create an accurate one (Chapter 16). A good term is clear and short, has one meaning, and follows the language's normal rules for making words.
5. **Record** it in your term list, and **share** the list with your team.

Step 4: record your terms

Here is part of a simple term list:

English term	Arabic term	Field	Note
<i>governing law</i>	القانون الواجب التطبيق	Legal	Also القانون المطبّق; القانون الحاكم is a common calque
<i>provided that</i>	شريطة أن	Legal	A contract condition
<i>Article (of a law)</i>	مادة	Legal	A contract <i>clause</i> is بند
CBC	تعداد الدم الكامل	Medical	Also صورة الدم الكاملة

Other tools help too:

- **Specialised dictionary** (Chapter 20): the terms of one field.
- **Termbase:** each entry holds the term in each language, with its definition, field, source and date. A team can share and update it.
- **Terminology guide:** the client's approved terms and writing rules. Always ask for one, and follow it.

Step 5: use one term for one idea

Suppose *Article* is مَادَّة in the first paragraph. Later you switch to بند “for variety”. Your reader now thinks you mean something new, because a new word suggests a new meaning.

When terms are not managed, one concept gets several names. Readers get confused, and earlier translations are harder to reuse. So use the same term throughout, and do not change an accepted term without a good reason.

Try it

1. What is the difference between a translator and a terminologist?
2. Is *LASER* an initialism or an acronym?
3. What should you do when no dictionary gives you the term?

Answers

1. A translator translates whole texts; a terminologist collects, records and sometimes standardises the terms of a field.
2. An acronym: the letters are read as a word.
3. Search the client’s guide, UNTERM and Arabterm; if there is still no term, think like a terminologist: create an accurate equivalent and record it.

REMEMBER

- Keep a term list for every project, and ask for the client's guide.
- Search the academies, UNTERM and Arabterm before you create a term.
- Use one term for one idea.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Term** (المصطلح): A word or expression that names a concept in a special field.
- **Terminology** (علم المصطلح (المصطلحية)): The study, collection and management of specialised terms; also the set of terms used in one field.
- **Terminologist** (المصطلحي (خبير المصطلحات)): A specialist who collects, describes and records the terms of a field, and sometimes standardises them, in one or more languages.
- **Term list** (قائمة المصطلحات): A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations.
- **Termbase** (قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات (بنك المصطلحات)): A database of terms and information about them.
- **Terminology guide** (دليل المصطلحات): A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client.

Chapter 22: Machine translation and AI

Where we are. Many translators now work with software, from translation memories to AI chat tools. This chapter shows you what these tools do, where they go wrong, and how to correct their output safely.

Step 1: meet the tools

- **Machine translation:** early systems used rules, then statistics; today most use neural networks. Neural systems are much more fluent, but they can still be wrong.
- **Translation memory:** stores your past translations sentence by sentence and suggests them when a similar sentence appears. It saves time and keeps your work consistent.
- **Termbases:** help you keep one term for one idea across a project (Chapter 21).
- **CAT tools** combine these, for example Trados, memoQ, and the free OmegaT and Matecat.

Step 2: decide when a machine can help

Machine translation can give a first draft of a simple text, or help you check your ideas. It is risky for legal, medical and religious texts, idioms, poetry and confidential texts.

You, not the machine, are responsible for the final translation (Kenny, 2022).

Step 3: learn the machine's typical mistakes

- *It's raining cats and dogs.* → إنها تمطر قططاً وكلاباً: the idiom is translated word by word. Correct: تمطر بغزارة.
- *The doctor finished her shift.* → أنهى الطبيب نوبته: the machine made the doctor a man, although the English says *her*. Correct: أنهت الطبيبة نوبتها.
- AI tools may add facts that are not in the text. This is called **hallucination**.

Step 4: correct the machine's output

Our new branch opens on Monday. Don't miss out!

- Machine output: !فرعنا الجديد يفتح يوم الاثنين. لا تفوت الخروج ✗ (*miss out* was read as “going out”)
- Corrected: !يُفتتح فرعنا الجديد يوم الاثنين. لا تفوتوا الفرصة ✓

Correcting a machine translation like this is called **post-editing**. The course materials call it the new direction for translators worldwide (Translation Team, n.d.). **Light** post-editing (التحرير اللاحق الخفيف) makes the text accurate and understandable; **full** post-editing (التحرير اللاحق الكامل) also makes it natural and ready to publish.

To post-edit, first compare the output with the source sentence by sentence. Then read it again as a normal text.

Step 5: use AI tools well, and adapt the whole product

- Tell the tool the text type, the audience and the terms you want.
- Ask for two or three options, then choose yourself.
- Check every name, number, date and term against a reliable source.

In localisation (Chapter 1), translation is only one part. Also adapt dates, numbers, currencies and units, images and colours, and the direction of the page: an Arabic website reads from right to left.

Step 6: follow four safety rules

1. You are responsible for every word.
2. Never put a client's private text into a public AI tool.
3. Check terms, names, numbers, idioms and every “not”.
4. Tell the client if you used a machine or AI.

Try it

1. Should you paste a client's confidential contract into a free AI tool?
2. What is post-editing?

Answers

1. No, never.
2. A human correcting and improving machine translation.

REMEMBER

- Machine translation is a first draft, not a final translation.
- Always post-edit, and protect your client's privacy.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Machine translation (MT)** (الترجمة الآلية): Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools.
- **Post-editing** (التحرير اللاحق): A human correcting and improving machine translation output, lightly or fully.
- **Hallucination** (الهلوسة): Invented or false content produced by an AI tool, such as facts that are not in the source text.
- **Translation memory** (ذاكرة الترجمة): A database of earlier translations that the translator can reuse.
- **CAT tool** (أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب): Computer-assisted translation software that helps a human translator, usually with a translation memory and a termbase.

Part 8: Checking and explaining

Chapter 23: Revision and common mistakes

Where we are. You can now translate, with or without a machine. Next, you check your work before anyone else sees it. By the end, you will be able to revise a draft in three readings and spot common mistakes.

Step 1: read your draft three times

Every translator makes mistakes in a draft, even experts. Revision is where you find them. Checking your own draft is called **self-revision** (Mossop, 2014). Read it three times:

1. **With the original:** is anything missing, added or changed?
2. **Without the original:** does it sound natural? If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.
3. **The details:** numbers, names, spelling, punctuation, titles and captions.

Step 2: check your Arabic (EN → AR)

Each line shows a weak version, then a better one:

- Starting every sentence with the subject (correct, but it sounds translated):
...الحكومة أعلنت... → أعلنت الحكومة
- Overusing the Arabic passive: قام بـ: قام الوزير بزيارة الكويت → زار الوزير الكويت
- Copying the English passive: تم افتتاح المعرض من قِبَل الوزير → افتتح الوزير المعرض
- Numbers 3 to 10: ثلاث طلاب → ثلاثة طلاب
- Hamza and taa marbuta: إنشاء، مدرسه، الى → إنشاء، مدرسة، إلى
- Word-for-word collocations: كسر القانون → خالف القانون
- English punctuation: نعم، سأحضر. هل ستحضر أنت؟ → نعم، سأحضر. هل ستحضر أنت؟ أنت؟

Step 3: check your English (AR → EN)

- Long sentences joined with “and”: split them with full stops.
- Repeated synonyms: *brave and daring* → *very brave*
- An extra “the”: *The life is beautiful.* → *Life is beautiful.*
- A missing “is”: *He in the office.* → *He is in the office.*
- Arabic prepositions: *He married from her.* → *He married her.*
- Missing capital letters in a title before a name: *minister of health Ahmad Ali* → *Minister of Health Ahmad Ali*

Try it

1. Improve: *قام المدير بتوقيع العقد.*
2. Improve: *She is a doctor in the hospital and she works hard and she likes her job.*

Answers

1. *وقع المديرُ العقد.*
2. *She is a doctor at the hospital. She works hard and likes her job.*

REMEMBER

- Read your translation once **without** the original.
- If a sentence sounds translated, rewrite it.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Draft** (المسودة): The first version of a translation.
- **Revision** (المراجعة): Checking a translation against the source and correcting it.
- **Self-revision** (المراجعة الذاتية): Revising your own translation.

Chapter 24: Interlingual risk assessment

Where we are. Some mistakes do far more harm than others. This chapter gives you a simple table that shows where to check most carefully after revision (Chapter 23).

Step 1: see why some mistakes matter more

A wrong dose in a medicine leaflet or a missing “not” in a contract can cause real harm. So the more serious the possible harm, the more care a text needs. Seen this way, translating is a kind of **risk management** (Pym, 2015).

Step 2: look at the risk matrix

This table lists the main risk areas in English–Arabic translation, how serious each is, and what to do. It is called a **risk matrix**.

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Terms	<i>governing law</i> → القانون الواجب التطبيق	High in legal texts	Check a specialised dictionary and the term list
Negatives	A lost “not” reverses the meaning	High	Compare sentence by sentence
Numbers and dates	A wrong dose; Hijri or Gregorian date	High	Check every figure twice
Legal verbs	<i>shall</i> → سوف ✗	High in contracts	Use the Arabic present tense for obligations
Sensitive names	<i>Persian Gulf</i> / <i>Arabian Gulf</i>	Medium to high	Follow the client's policy; explain in the commentary
Ideological words	انتحاري / استشهادي	Medium to high	Follow the client's policy (Chapter 19)
Cultural images	<i>warmed my heart</i> → أدفأ قلبي ✗	Medium	Use cultural approximation (Chapter 14)
Words with several meanings	عَلِمَ (flag), عِلْم (knowledge) or عِلِمَ (knew)?	Medium	Read the context (Chapter 6)
Style and register	A dialect word in a formal report	Low to medium	Re-read with the brief in mind

Risk area	Example	Risk level	What to do
Idioms	An idiom translated word by word	Medium	Check whether it is an idiom (Chapter 8)

Step 3: use the matrix before you deliver

1. Check your translation against each row.
2. Give most time to the high-risk areas.
3. For high-risk texts, such as legal and medical ones, ask a second person to check.

Example: *This Agreement shall be governed by the laws of the State of Kuwait.* →
 (سوف تخضع هذه الاتفاقية لقوانين دولة الكويت).

Try it

1. What is the main risk in *Take one tablet twice daily*?
2. What should you do with a high-risk text?

Answers

1. The dose: the numbers must be exactly right.
2. Check it with extra care, and ask a second person to review it.

REMEMBER

- Check numbers, names, negatives, terms and legal verbs every time.
- The higher the risk, the more careful the check.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Risk** (الخطر): The chance that a choice causes a problem, and how serious it would be.
- **Risk management** (إدارة المخاطر): Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm.
- **Risk matrix** (مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر): A table of possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do.

Chapter 25: Translation commentary

Where we are. You can now translate and check a text. Often you must also explain your choices. This chapter shows you how to write a commentary, the third phase after analysis and translation.

Step 1: understand what a commentary is for

In a maths exam, you show your working, not just the answer. A **translation commentary** does the same for a translation: it shows your thinking. It sharpens your reasoning and helps you judge translations, your own and other people's (Dickins et al., 2016).

Step 2: plan the two parts

1. **Reflecting on your analysis:** which problems did it identify?
2. **Reflecting on your translation:** how did you solve each problem?

Step 3: answer five questions for each problem

1. **The problem:** what was difficult?
2. **The solution:** what did you write?
3. **The procedure or strategy:** which technique did you use (Chapters 9 to 16)?
4. **The resource:** which dictionary or source did you check?
5. **The justification:** why is your choice right for the reader?

Step 4: write it clearly

- Write in the **third person**: "The translator faced...", "The translator changed some parts to make them more comprehensible..."
- Let WH-questions guide you: what, why, how?
- Always give examples from the source and the translation.

- Explain omissions, for example: “This was omitted because it is irrelevant to the target audience.”
- Mention the dictionaries and resources you used.
- Keep it short and clear.

An example:

The source text says the agreement “remained a dead letter”. A literal translation, حرفاً ميتاً, would confuse Arab readers, so the translator chose the functional equivalent حبراً على ورق. The expression was checked in Arabic newspapers. It is a familiar idiom and suits the formal style of a news report.

Try it

1. Write one commentary sentence for *strong tea* → شاي ثقيل.

Answers

1. For example: “*Strong tea* is a collocation, so it could not be translated word by word; the translator used the Arabic partner شاي ثقيل, which sounds natural to Arab readers.”

REMEMBER

- Analysis → translation → commentary.
- For each problem: problem, solution, procedure or strategy, resource, justification.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Translation commentary** (التعليق على الترجمة): A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions.
- **Justification** (التبرير): The reason why a translation choice is right.

Part 9: Audiovisual translation

Chapter 26: Introduction to audiovisual translation

Where we are. So far you have translated words on a page. Now you move to films, series and games, where words work with pictures and sound. By the end, you will know the main types and how to begin.

Step 1: see what makes a video different

Films, series, games and online videos are part of almost everyone's life today (Pérez-González, 2014). Driven by technology, **audiovisual translation** (AVT) is one of the fastest-growing areas of Translation Studies.

- It depends heavily on technology.
- **Images, sound** (dialogue, music, sound effects) and **written words** on screen work together to make meaning.
- The translator must connect the words with the pictures and sound (Gambier, 2003).

Step 2: know the main types

- **Subtitling:** written text on the screen (Chapter 27).
- **Dubbing:** new dialogue in the target language, often matched to the actors' lips.
- **Voice-over:** a translation read over the original voice, as in documentaries.
- **Audio description:** a spoken description of the action, for blind and partially sighted viewers.

Dubbing is used for cartoons, games and commercials, and in the Arab world for many children's programmes and series. Its challenges are matching lip movements, adapting cultural content and staying consistent across a series. When

the cartoon *The Simpsons* was dubbed into Arabic as آل شمشون, the family's habits were adapted for Arab family viewers: Homer's beer, for example, became a soft drink (Translation Team, n.d.).

Step 3: put the purpose first

A cartoon for children and a documentary for adults need very different choices. So before you translate a video, ask what it is for and who will watch it. This idea is called **Skopos theory** (Reiss & Vermeer, 1984).

Step 4: prepare for the challenges

- **Culture:** a reference may have no equivalent (Chapters 14 to 16).
- **Language:** English and Arabic are built differently, yet you must be accurate and brief (Chapter 3).
- **Technology:** subtitles have strict limits of space and time.
- **Creativity:** jokes, wordplay, songs and slang need creative solutions.

Step 5: take your first steps

1. Watch the whole video first, then read the script or dialogue list.
2. Ask for the brief: subtitles or dubbing? For which viewers? In which Arabic?
3. Practise with free subtitling software, such as Subtitle Edit or Aegisub.
4. Watch films with Arabic subtitles and notice what the subtitler shortened.

Try it

1. What are the three elements of an audiovisual text?
2. Which type of AVT describes the action on screen for blind viewers?
3. What does Skopos theory put first?

Answers

1. Images, sound and written words.
2. Audio description.
3. The purpose of the translation.

REMEMBER

- AVT combines images, sound and words, and depends on technology.
- Main types: subtitling, dubbing, voice-over and audio description.
- The purpose and the viewers decide how you translate.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Audiovisual translation (AVT)** (الترجمة السمعية البصرية): Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games.
- **Dubbing** (الدبلجة): Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language.
- **Voice-over** (التعليق الصوتي): Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly.
- **Audio description** (الوصف الصوتي): A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind and partially sighted viewers.
- **Skopos theory** (نظرية الغاية): The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated.

Chapter 27: Subtitling

Where we are. Chapter 26 introduced audiovisual translation. Now you will focus on subtitles. By the end, you will be able to write and check a subtitle, and handle cultural references and strong language.

Step 1: learn the limits of a subtitle

Viewers read while they watch, so a subtitle normally has one or two lines. Each line traditionally holds about 37 to 39 characters; streaming platforms now allow up to 42. It must stay on screen long enough to be read, usually from about one to six or seven seconds. It must also appear and disappear with the speech: marking these in and out times is called **spotting** (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2021). Always follow the client's guidelines.

There are several kinds:

- **Intralingual:** the same language as the dialogue, for example subtitles for the deaf and hard of hearing (**SDH**), which also describe important sounds, or subtitles for language learners.
- **Interlingual:** another language; what translators usually make.
- **Pre-prepared** (offline) or **live** (online), as in live news.
- **Open** (burned into the picture) or **closed** (can be turned on and off).

Step 2: subtitle a clip

1. Watch the whole film or video, with the dialogue list if you have one.
2. **Spot** the subtitles: mark when each one starts and ends.
3. Translate the meaning of each line.
4. **Condense:** cut what viewers can see or do not need, such as repetitions and fillers like *well* and *you know*.
5. Check the length, reading time and line breaks, then watch the video with your subtitles.

A condensed line:

Well, you know, I really don't think we should go out tonight, because it's going to rain.

لا أظنّ أن علينا الخروج الليلة، فالمطر قادم.

The fillers disappear, and the meaning stays.

Step 3: write good Arabic subtitles

- Write in Modern Standard Arabic, even when the characters speak a dialect, unless the client asks otherwise.
- Break a line where the meaning breaks: keep a noun with its adjective, a preposition with its noun, and pairs such as مدير المدرسة together.
- Use Arabic punctuation.
- Work with the images, dialogue, music and sound effects. If the picture already shows something, the subtitle can be shorter. If the words refer to something on screen, make sure the subtitle still matches it.

It is not easy. Viewers who know some of the source language hear the original and read your translation, so they notice mistakes. Speech must be cut down to short written lines. And how characters speak shows who they are: their **sociolect** (social group), **slang** and **idiolect** (personal habits). Even in MSA, try to keep some of this through your choice of words.

Step 4: handle cultural references

Cultural references, or **culture-bound terms**, may be **geographical** (places), **ethnographic** (food, holidays, daily life) or **socio-political** (government, institutions) (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007).

The most useful strategies are (Díaz Cintas & Remael, 2007; Pedersen, 2011):

1. **Loan** (retention): keep the source word.
2. **Calque** (direct translation): translate it word for word.

3. **Explicitation** (specification): add a little information.
4. **Generalisation**: use a more general word.
5. **Substitution**: use something familiar to the audience.
6. **Official equivalent**: use the accepted translation, if there is one.
7. **Compensation**: make up for a lost effect somewhere else.
8. **Omission**: leave it out when it is unimportant and there is no space.

You met most of these in Chapters 12 and 13. In subtitling, you must also respect limits of space and time.

Step 5: handle strong and taboo language

Films use swearing and other forbidden words for realism, character or humour. This is called **taboo language**. Subtitlers often soften it, for several reasons: swear words look stronger in writing than in speech; audiences have different norms; and broadcasters or authorities may require it (**censorship**), or subtitlers may choose it themselves (self-censorship). Follow the client's guidelines, and keep the emotion of the scene where you can.

Try it

1. What is the difference between open and closed subtitles?
2. Which strategy uses an accepted translation?
3. Why do viewers notice mistakes in subtitles easily?

Answers

1. Open subtitles are burned into the picture; closed subtitles can be turned on and off.
2. The official equivalent.
3. Because they hear the original and read the translation at the same time, and many understand some of the original.

REMEMBER

- A subtitle normally has no more than two short lines, stays on screen long enough to be read, and works with images and sound.
- Choose a strategy for each cultural reference, within the limits of space and time.
- Follow the client's guidelines on strong language.

WORDS TO REMEMBER

- **Subtitling** (الترجمة المرئية / السترجة): Showing a written version of the dialogue, usually at the bottom of the screen, together with important on-screen text and song lyrics.
- **Dialogue list** (قائمة الحوار): A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator.
- **Culture-bound term** (مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية): A reference to something from one culture, such as a food or a holiday. Also called a culture-specific item (Chapter 14).
- **Taboo language** (اللغة المحظورة): Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words.
- **Censorship** (الرقابة): Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable.

Abbreviations

- **AI:** artificial intelligence (الذكاء الاصطناعي)
- **AR → EN:** from Arabic into English
- **AVT:** audiovisual translation (الترجمة السمعية البصرية)
- **CAT:** computer-assisted translation (الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب)
- **EN → AR:** from English into Arabic
- **MSA:** Modern Standard Arabic (الفصحى المعاصرة)
- **MT:** machine translation (الترجمة الآلية)
- **SDH:** subtitles for the deaf and hard of hearing
- **SL:** source language (اللغة المصدر); **SLC:** source language culture (ثقافة اللغة المصدر)
- **ST:** source text (النص المصدر)
- **TL:** target language (اللغة الهدف); **TLC:** target language culture (ثقافة اللغة الهدف)
- **TS:** Translation Studies (دراسات الترجمة)
- **TT:** target text (النص الهدف)

Further reading

If you want to go further, start with these books. Full details are in the References.

- **Baker (2018)**, *In other words*: the classic coursebook, with problems and strategies at word, grammar and text level.
- **Ghazala (2008)**, *Translation as problems and solutions*: English–Arabic examples of common problems, each with its solutions.
- **Dickins et al. (2016)**, *Thinking Arabic translation*: a practical course in translating from Arabic into English.
- **Newmark (1988)**, *A textbook of translation*: methods and procedures, with many examples.
- **Díaz Cintas and Remael (2021)**, *Subtitling*: a practical guide to the subtitler's work, with many examples.

Glossary

All the key terms defined in this handbook, in alphabetical order, with the chapter where each one is explained.

Adaptation (method) التكيف A very free rewriting; some specialists see it as a new text, not a translation. (Chapter 10)

Adaptation (procedure) التكيف Replacing a cultural situation with a familiar one; smaller in scale than adaptation as a method (Chapter 10). (Chapter 12)

Addition الإضافة Adding words or information that the reader needs. (Chapter 13)

Approximation التقريب Rendering the meaning of the source text as closely as possible in the target language, knowing that an exact match is impossible. (Chapter 1)

Audio description الوصف الصوتي A spoken description of what happens on screen, for blind and partially sighted viewers. (Chapter 26)

Audiovisual translation (AVT) الترجمة السمعية البصرية Translating texts that combine words, images and sound, such as films and video games. (Chapter 26)

Bilingual dictionary معجم ثنائي اللغة A dictionary that gives equivalents in another language. (Chapter 20)

Borrowing الاقتراض Taking a word from the source language as it is. (Chapter 12)

Calque النسخ Translating each part of an expression literally; also called loan translation (Chapter 16). (Chapter 12)

CAT tool أداة الترجمة بمساعدة الحاسوب Computer-assisted translation software that helps a human translator, usually with a translation memory and a termbase. (Chapter 22)

Censorship الرقابة Removing or changing content that is considered unacceptable. (Chapter 27)

Client العميل The person or organisation that asks for a translation. (Chapter 2)

Collocation التلازم اللفظي Words that naturally go together; the company a word keeps. (Chapter 7)

Collocations dictionary معجم المتلازمات اللفظية A dictionary of the natural word partners of a language. (Chapter 20)

Commissioned translator مترجم بتكليف A translator who translates a text at someone else's request. (Chapter 1)

Communicative purpose الغرض التواصلي What the translation is for: to inform, persuade, instruct or entertain. (Chapter 2)

Compensation التعويض Making up for an effect lost in one place by creating a similar effect elsewhere. (Chapter 13)

Concept المفهوم An idea that a word or term stands for. (Chapter 15)

Connotation المعنى الإيحائي The extra feeling or association a word carries. (Chapter 5)

Context السياق Everything around a word or text that helps us understand it: the surrounding words and the wider situation. (Chapter 6)

Cultural approximation التقريب الثقافي Bringing the source text's cultural meaning as close as possible to the target reader. (Chapter 14)

Cultural substitution الاستبدال الثقافي Replacing a cultural reference with one that is familiar to the target reader. (Chapter 13)

Culture-bound term مصطلح ذو خصوصية ثقافية A reference to something from one culture, such as a food or a holiday. Also called a culture-specific item (Chapter 14). (Chapter 27)

Culture-specific item عنصر ذو خصوصية ثقافية A word, custom or reference that belongs to one culture. (Chapter 14)

Denotation المعنى المعجمي The basic, dictionary meaning of a word. (Chapter 5)

Descriptive translation الترجمة الوصفية Paraphrasing a source expression by describing its meaning. Also called explanatory translation (الترجمة الشرحية), Chapter 13). (Chapter 15)

Dialect اللهجة العامية The everyday spoken Arabic of a country or region. (Chapter 3)

Dialogue list قائمة الحوار A written script of everything said in a film, given to the translator. (Chapter 27)

Domestication التوطين Making a translation feel local to the target reader. (Chapter 13)

Draft المسودة The first version of a translation. (Chapter 23)

Dubbing الدبلجة Replacing the original dialogue with recorded dialogue in the target language. (Chapter 26)

Equivalence التكافؤ A match between a source-language expression and a target-language expression. (Chapter 9)

Equivalence (procedure) التكافؤ Describing the same situation with a completely different expression, often an idiom or a proverb; narrower than equivalence in general (Chapter 9). (Chapter 12)

Explanatory translation الترجمة الشرحية Explaining a word or expression that has no equivalent. (Chapter 13)

Field المجال The subject area of a text, such as politics, health or law. (Chapter 17)

Figurative language اللغة المجازية Language used in a non-literal way to create an image or effect. (Chapter 11)

Fixed expression العبارة المسكوكة A fixed group of words whose meaning is clear from its words, such as *as a matter of fact*. (Chapter 8)

Foreignisation التغريب Keeping the foreign flavour of the source text. (Chapter 13)

Form الشكل The structure of language: a word, phrase, clause, sentence or text. (Chapter 4)

Formal equivalence التكافؤ الشكلي Keeping the form of the original: passive for passive, verb for verb. (Chapter 9)

Free translation الترجمة الحرة Keeping the message but not the form; also called loose translation. (Chapter 10)

Functional equivalence التكافؤ الوظيفي Using a target-language expression that serves the same function, whatever its form. (Chapter 9)

Functional translation الترجمة الوظيفية Translating with a target-language expression that has the same function. (Chapter 13)

Genre الجنس النصي A kind of text with its own rules, such as a news report, a contract or a poem. (Chapter 17)

Hallucination الهلوسة Invented or false content produced by an AI tool, such as facts that are not in the source text. (Chapter 22)

Headline العنوان الرئيسي The title of a news story. (Chapter 18)

Homonymy المشترك اللفظي One word with several meanings that are not related. (Chapter 6)

Ideational equivalence التكافؤ الفكري Giving only the basic idea, in plain words. (Chapter 9)

Ideology الأيديولوجيا A set of beliefs that shapes how people describe events. (Chapter 19)

Idiom التعبير الاصطلاحي A fixed expression whose meaning is not the sum of the meanings of its words. (Chapter 8)

Interpreting الترجمة الشفهية Transferring spoken language into another language. (Chapter 1)

Inverted pyramid الهرم المقلوب A news structure that gives the most important facts first. (Chapter 18)

Justification التبرير The reason why a translation choice is right. (Chapter 25)

Lexical creation التوليد المعجمي Coining new target-language words for items with no direct equivalent. (Chapter 16)

Lexical gap الفجوة المعجمية A concept that has a word in one language but not in the other. (Chapter 5)

Literal translation الترجمة الحرفية Keeping the original words, changing only what grammar requires; also called modified literal translation (الترجمة الحرفية المعدلة). (Chapter 10)

Loaded word كلمة مشحونة A word that carries a judgement, positive or negative. (Chapter 19)

Loan translation (calque) النسخ Translating the parts of a compound word one by one. (Chapter 16)

Machine translation (MT) الترجمة الآلية Translation done by software, such as online translation tools or AI chat tools. (Chapter 22)

Macro context سياق الموقف (الخارجي) The wider situation: the author, audience, time, place and circumstances of a text. (Chapter 6)

Meaning المعنى The idea that a form expresses. (Chapter 4)

Mental draft المسودة الذهنية A first idea of the translation that you form while reading the text. (Chapter 2)

Metaphor الاستعارة A comparison without “as” or “like”; using a word in a non-basic meaning. (Chapter 11)

Micro context (co-text) السياق اللغوي (الداخلي) The words and sentences immediately around a word. (Chapter 6)

Modern Standard Arabic (MSA) الفصحى المعاصرة The Arabic of newspapers, laws and education. (Chapter 3)

Modulation التطويع Expressing the same idea from another point of view. (Chapter 12)

Monolingual dictionary معجم أحادي اللغة A dictionary that explains words in the same language. (Chapter 20)

Neologism اللفظ المستحدث A new word, or an existing word given a new meaning. (Chapter 16)

Omission الحذف Leaving out words that are unnecessary in the target language. (Chapter 13)

Polysemy تعدد المعنى One word with several meanings that are related. (Chapter 6)

Post-editing التحرير اللاحق A human correcting and improving machine translation output, lightly or fully. (Chapter 22)

Proverb المثل A traditional saying that gives advice or states a truth. (Chapter 8)

Register المستوى اللغوي How formal or informal the language is. (Chapter 3)

Revision المراجعة Checking a translation against the source and correcting it. (Chapter 23)

Risk الخطر The chance that a choice causes a problem, and how serious it would be. (Chapter 24)

Risk management إدارة المخاطر Spending more effort where a mistake could cause more harm. (Chapter 24)

Risk matrix مصفوفة تقييم المخاطر A table of possible risks, how serious they are, and what to do. (Chapter 24)

Self-initiated translator مترجم بمبادرة ذاتية A translator who chooses a text to translate on their own initiative. (Chapter 1)

Self-revision المراجعة الذاتية Revising your own translation. (Chapter 23)

Sentence meaning معنى الجملة What the words of a sentence say. (Chapter 5)

Simile التشبيه A comparison that uses “as” or “like”. (Chapter 11)

Skopos theory نظرية الغاية The idea that the purpose of a translation decides how it is translated. (Chapter 26)

Source text (ST) النص المصدر The original text that you translate. (Chapter 1)

Speaker meaning مقصد المتكلم What the speaker really means by saying it. (Chapter 5)

Specialised dictionary معجم متخصص A dictionary for one field, such as law or medicine. (Chapter 20)

Subtitling الترجمة المرئية / السترجة Showing a written version of the dialogue, usually at the bottom of the screen, together with important on-screen text and song lyrics. (Chapter 27)

Taboo language اللغة المحظورة Words that a society or religion forbids or restricts, such as swear words. (Chapter 27)

Target audience الجمهور المستهدف The people who will read the translation. (Chapter 2)

Target text (TT) النص الهدف Your translation. (Chapter 1)

Term المصطلح A word or expression that names a concept in a special field. (Chapter 21)

Term list قائمة المصطلحات A list of the approved terms for a project, with their translations. (Chapter 21)

Termbase قاعدة بيانات المصطلحات (بنك المصطلحات) A database of terms and information about them. (Chapter 21)

Terminologist المصطلحي (خبير المصطلحات) A specialist who collects, describes and records the terms of a field, and sometimes standardises them, in one or more languages. (Chapter 21)

Terminology علم المصطلح (المصطلحية) The study, collection and management of specialised terms; also the set of terms used in one field. (Chapter 21)

Terminology guide دليل المصطلحات A document that tells translators which terms to use for a client. (Chapter 21)

Text النص Any piece of language, written or spoken, that forms a complete message: from a one-word sign to a whole book. (Chapter 17)

Text analysis تحليل النص Breaking down and studying a text before translating it. (Chapter 17)

Text type نمط النص A group of texts that share one main function: to inform, to express or to persuade. (Chapter 18)

Tone النبرة The writer's attitude, for example neutral, critical or friendly. (Chapter 17)

Translation الترجمة Transferring meaning from one language into another. In a narrow sense, written translation (الترجمة التحريرية), as opposed to interpreting. (Chapter 1)

Translation brief موجز الترجمة The client's instructions for a translation: who it is for, what it is for and any other requirements. (Chapter 2)

Translation commentary التعليق على الترجمة A text that explains the problems in a translation and justifies the solutions. (Chapter 25)

Translation memory ذاكرة الترجمة A database of earlier translations that the translator can reuse. (Chapter 22)

Translation procedure إجراء الترجمة A technique for translating a word, phrase or sentence. (Chapter 12)

Translation strategy استراتيجية الترجمة A planned solution to a translation problem. (Chapter 13)

Transliteration النقل الصوتي Writing the sounds of a word in the letters of another language. (Chapter 15)

Transposition الإبدال Changing the word class, for example a noun into a verb. (Chapter 12)

Verbal sentence الجملة الفعلية A sentence that starts with a verb. (Chapter 3)

Voice-over التعليق الصوتي Recording a translation over the original voice, which can still be heard quietly. (Chapter 26)

Word order ترتيب الكلمات The order of the subject, verb and object in a sentence. (Chapter 3)

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